



Unbreakable bond: Kanika Siwach, a promising centre forward, with her mother, Pritam, who has been her mentor, coach, and constant source of strength on and off the field. **Right:** Kanika playing for Odisha Warriors at the Women's Hockey India League. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT & SHAHSHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

A lot of that has to do with culture, says Pritam. "I think the difference, why there are next to no mother-daughter generations in Indian hockey, is that many women raise their children, especially their daughters, very protectively. They think of all the struggles they had to go through and don't want their daughters to face the same," she says. "It comes down to how brave you are and how much trust and confidence you have in your daughter. It's not easy in India. If you've been an elite player, chances are you could provide an easier path for your children. You might think, 'Okay, I'll make them study, get them married well, and ensure a good job in the private sector.'"

That, Pritam feels, limits what girls

can achieve. "In choosing this safer path, we forget that our daughters have to be happy. I always wanted my daughter to play. Sport made me happy. I want my daughter to experience that as well," she says.

Kanika says she was never pressured into the sport. "I grew up playing everything. Initially, I didn't even care much about hockey. At home, everyone played hockey — my father, mother and brother. During dinner, everyone would constantly talk about it. At that time, I didn't like it because I couldn't understand what they were talking about. But eventually I started playing and found out that I liked it," she says.

Although her mother was a respected player and coach, Kanika insists she didn't get any special

treatment. "Nothing was made easy for me. In fact, I felt my mother was extra strict with me because she never wanted to be accused of favouritism. When I was in Class 6, I went for my first competition outside Sonipat. We stayed in a government school where we slept on the bare floor on bedsheets. The washrooms were dirty. I had never experienced anything like that, so I called my mother and asked how I could stay there. She told me, 'Stay like the rest of your teammates are,'" Kanika says.

Pritam remembers that moment vividly. "I knew those were the facilities you get playing hockey in India. If I tried to protect her, then she would never learn to accept it. She wouldn't get the toughness she needed to survive as an Indian